all available evidence suggests that its onward march cannot be stopped. The traditional model of distribution and retailing will have to yield space to e-commerce sooner or later.

India has adopted a policy stance of providing only limited space to foreign e-commerce companies in trade services; the most restrictive is the retailing regime. Indian companies like Flipkart also suffer the same treatment when they receive FDI. Domestic organized retail gets more favourable treatment. E-commerce rules recently proposed under the Consumer Protection Act bring domestic e-commerce companies within the policy regime, providing more restrictive and differential treatment to protect the small traditional traders.

Traditional retail has been in the business of retailing goods. Retailing of services has been totally disorganized. Traditional retail stores did not provide services. The e-commerce revolution is bringing order in retailing of services. Repair and maintenance services are getting better organized through several start-ups in this space. There is no reason why traditional goods retail stores cannot also retail services.

With the inevitable transition of agricultural labour and farmers from agriculture, the retail segment, for both goods and services, offers a very promising field of occupation for transitioning labour. It needs to be better organized and supported. Accordingly, a supportive policy framework for building further momentum in trade and repair services, potentially to raise its share to 12.5 per cent of GDP by 2035, is required, as follows:

First, support extensive training of transitioning agricultural labour and farmers for myriad services that urbanizing India and developing rural India need: delivery persons, security persons, vehicle repairers, home workers, drivers, construction workers, plumbers, electricians, IT device carers and painters, to name a few.

Besides imparting the right training and skilling, the employment of these workers needs to be optimized through two major interventions: